

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Set Up a Montessori Corner in One Afternoon

A checklist for small homes · Ages 2–4

A 'prepared environment' just means a space where your child can choose, use and put away things on their own. Start with one corner. You can always grow it later.

What the research found

- ○ Toddlers with 4 toys available played twice as long with each toy, and in more varied ways, than toddlers with 16 toys (Dauch et al., 2018).

The checklist

- ○ Pick a quiet corner away from the TV.
- ○ One low shelf, child's eye level. A bookshelf on its side works.
- ○ 6–8 toys only, spaced apart.
- ○ One basket or tray per toy or set.
- ○ A small rug to define the play space.
- ○ A floor cushion and 3–5 books displayed face-out.
- ○ One plant (real or not) for warmth.

Good toys to start with

- ○ A stacking or nesting toy
- ○ A simple wooden puzzle (3–6 pieces)
- ○ A basket of balls or blocks
- ○ A pouring or spooning tray
- ○ A small car or animal set
- ○ Crayons and paper

Toy rotation in 3 steps

- ○ Store the other toys in a box, out of sight.
- ○ Every week, swap 2–3 toys your child has stopped using.
- ○ Keep favourites out until interest fades naturally.

Signs it's working

Your child chooses toys on their own, plays longer, and starts putting things back with less help.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Dauch, C., Imwalle, M., Ocasio, B., & Metz, A. E. (2018). The influence of the number of toys in the environment on toddlers' play. Infant Behavior and Development, 50, 78–87.